

Course report – Free standing courses and courses within Europaprogrammet (EP), Master of European Studies (MAES), Master of European Studies Humanities track (HMAES), Executive Master of European Studies (EMAES)

Course name, course code, programme and semester Applied Qualitative Research Methods, Problems and Design, SF2323 Fall 2022	Course instructors' name och e-mail Anna Persson anna.persson@pol.gu.se
Output and achievement	Registered: 50; Completed the course: 30; Pass as the final grade: 19; High pass 11.
Note to the reader	Before we begin any discussion on the results of the course evaluation, it should be made clear that only 17 out of the 50 registered students responded to the evaluation – which corresponds to a mere 33 percent. One should thus be careful in making any more general assessments of the course solely based on the course evaluation.

Impressions of course execution: general and specific	Overall, my impression is that the course went quite well, particularly in the light of that it has gone through some quite thorough re-organization in terms of both administration, teachers, structure and content this year. The new structure means that some of the introductory lectures have been re-organized and also filled with new content (and with an in part a new teacher), with an increased focus on problem formulation and the connection between problem formulation, theory, and methodological approach. This re-organization in terms of structure and content is an attempt to even more firmly “set the stage” for the course already at an early stage so that even students that have limited or no previous methodological training stand a fair chance to follow the course. My impression is that this worked very well in terms of defining the overall framework of conducting qualitative research. Similar to before, following from this set of introductory lectures and seminars, the students are then introduced to four different branches of qualitative data collection and methods: interviews, observations, and two types of text analysis (discourse analysis and typology analysis). Out of these four themes, the students are asked to choose two (either interviews or observations and discourse analysis or typology analysis) to dig further into. The course is concluded with a research proposal on a topic of the students' own choice, with a focus on methodology and design. In preparation of the final research proposal, the students are offered both an introductory lecture with advice and ideas about how to write a research proposal, two group supervisions and one individual Q&A. Overall, the execution of the course worked well considering the circumstances with new administration, only one course instructor (compared to the previous two), and several new teachers. This is also reflected in the course evaluation. My view is that one major challenge still remains, however, and that is how to make all students equally happy about the course, regardless of previous methodological training. The few negative comments that are expressed in the course evaluation almost all stem from students who feel that the course is not challenging enough given their background knowledge. This is of course something I take very seriously, and I will continue thinking about how to develop the course so that <i>all</i> students feel engaged with and inspired by it. A few other things that I think might strengthen the course is to: 1) Add an even more “practical” aspect to the course, and; 2) Even further homogenize the seminars for the final papers so that all students meet the same format. It might moreover be worthwhile rethinking the structure of the four “themes” for data collection; is there anything that could be added to this? Or be merged (for instance discourse and typology analysis)?
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Impressions of the students' general views on the course	Overall, the students seem happy with the course: 57.1 percent found the course very good (21.4) or good (35.7) and many express that the course was well-received both in terms of structure and content. This is a slight improvement since last year, when 52.2 percent found the course very good (13) or good (39.1). The results are however somewhat bleaker compared to last year's evaluation if we take into account the students that were not very satisfied; whereas last year 21.1 percent of the students reported that they found the course very (4.3) or rather (13) bad, this year the corresponding number is 35.3 percent (11.8 percent very bad and 23.5 percent rather bad). What this increase in dissatisfied students stems from is difficult to say, but it does not seem to stem from dissatisfaction with the lectures and seminars. Compared to last year, the students seem to be even more satisfied with the lectures and seminars. Last year, 71.4 percent found the lectures and seminars very good (14.3 percent) or good (57.1 percent), and 2 respondents (14.3 percent) found them very or rather bad. This year, 82.4 percent of the respondents found the lectures and seminars very good (35.3 percent) or good (47.1 percent), and 1 respondent (5.9 percent) found them (very or) rather bad. The students moreover seem fairly happy with the literature: only two students found the literature to be rather bad, the remainder found it either neither good nor bad (47.1 percent), rather good (29.4 percent), or very good (11.8 percent).
Impressions of the students' specific views on the course	The students' specific views on the course reflect the overall positive feedback in the evaluations with regard to the satisfaction with the lectures and seminars. If we look for the more negative strands of comments, the few that exist seem to mainly concern: 1) Lack of coherence between supervisors and teachers/seminars and lectures, and 2) complaints about the course being not enough demanding. If we take a look at the evaluation statistics, this to some extent reflect the view that the course might not be that demanding for at least some of the students. When asked about workload, no student seem to find the course much too demanding and only 4 (23.5 percent) students in total say they find it somewhat too demanding. However, 7 students (41.2 percent) find it not that demanding (no student finds it not at all demanding). 35.3 percent of the respondents do at the same time report that they find the workload ok. This is a big change since last year when the large majority – 84.6 percent found the workload to be OK. Why a fewer number of students report that they find the workload other than OK this year is difficult to say. When asked about how much time they spend on the course, the great majority of students report that they spend less than 40 hours (which corresponds to full time studies) a week. Indeed, the evaluation reveals that 29.4 percent of the respondents have spent equal or less than 20 hours studying during the course, while 23.5 percent of the respondents report that they have spent even close to 40 hours on the course by ticking in the box 31-40 hours. It is not entirely clear how these figures should be interpreted. Independently of the students' reporting, a general view among the coordinators and teachers of the course is that the fact that there is no entrance requirements in terms of any previous knowledge of qualitative methods makes it a demanding course for teachers in terms of striking the right balance between students that already have a lot of knowledge and students that have in principal never encountered qualitative methods before. The fact that out of 50 students, only 30 have reached a final grade, seems to indicate that a quite substantial number of the students in fact find the course too demanding. At the same time, among the students' comments, one can only find students that find the course too easy for being at the master's level. As aforementioned, against this backdrop, I will continue thinking about how to develop the course so that <i>all</i> students feel engaged with and inspired by it – and can also pass it if a sufficient amount working hours are put into it.

Ideas about potential changes for the next time the course is given	Even though the course has undergone significant change this year, there is always room for improvement. As already discussed, my view is that the major challenge that still remains with this course is how to make all students equally happy with it, regardless of previous methodological training. A few other things that I think might strengthen the course and that can be taken care of in the short term is to: 1) Add an even more “practical” aspect to the course, and; 2) Even further homogenize the seminars for the final papers so that all students meet the same format. It might moreover be worthwhile rethinking the structure of the four “themes” for data collection; is there anything that could be added to this? Or be merged (for instance discourse and typology analysis)? The many students that have not yet finalized the course might bear witness of that the goals are still set somewhat too high given the background knowledge of the students. At the same time, however, as aforementioned, when asked how many hours they put into their studies each week, 0 percent report that they put in more than 40 hours. These figures might indicate that the course does not in fact have set the goals too high, but rather that at least some of the students do not prioritize their studies.
Ideas for long-term and / or more extensive changes	As the course was very much revised this year and since the course got quite good feedback in the student evaluation (even though there are of course still things to work on) – as for now, we plan to change the course primarily in line with the points listed above. This might take part within the larger framework of re-organization that is currently taking place at the master level.
"Aha Experiences" during the course of the course	Among the respondents, 29.4 percent reported that they got an “Eye-opening experience” during the course. To us teachers, whereas maybe not an “Aha experience” in that regard, what once again is made clear is the importance of introductory lectures to frame the course in a nice and coherent manner, as well as the importance of time to dedicate to the students’ needs and demands. Even this year, the student group was quite diverse in many different aspects, which require more in terms of the time and resources needed to meet the issues that come up (spanning from questions about whether the course could be given on Zoom, to feelings of homesickness, to critique that the course is too easy, to worries about not being able to meet the standards set for the course).
Expressions of how the Canvas-page and other administrative processes been like	Overall, the respondents seem to be very satisfied with the administration of the course: 70.6 percent report that they find the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas, to be very (29.4 percent) or rather (41.2 percent) good.
Other:	

* The Course reporting aims at responsiveness to the students' views, quality assurance of the business as well as subject and educational development. The report should have a forward-looking focus, based on the reflector's and visions of the course manager, and based on a compilation of impressions derived from the following amounts of material: comments by students individually or in groups; teacher's, study administrator and student counselor's views and impressions from the students; miter mining evaluation and the results from the course evaluation poll.